

Intersectionality Classroom Toolkit

A practical teacher guide and five reproducible pages for helping students notice how identity, power, access, and systems shape belonging.

THE CORE IDEA

People do not experience school through one identity at a time. Race, Indigeneity, gender, disability, language, religion, class, family structure, migration, and other parts of life can interact with rules, spaces, attitudes, and institutions. The interaction can create a distinct experience - not simply a list of separate advantages or barriers.

WHY IT MATTERS

A solution that helps one group may still exclude people within that group. An intersectional lens asks who is helped, who may still face barriers, whose knowledge counts, and what could change in the environment or system.

Five moves for everyday teaching

1. Notice the whole context Look beyond a single label. Ask what relationships, histories, spaces, expectations, resources, and responsibilities are shaping participation.	2. Examine systems, not students Shift from 'What is wrong with this learner?' to 'What barrier is being produced here, and by what routine, assumption, or design choice?'
3. Centre lived knowledge without demanding disclosure Use community-created texts and public testimony. Never make a student the spokesperson for an identity or ask the class to map private identities.	4. Include joy, agency, and resistance Do not teach communities only through harm. Include belonging, creativity, kinship, leadership, pleasure, survival, and movements for change.
5. Design with those most affected Invite voluntary, accessible input. Make the goal a change in access, policy, representation, relationships, or decision-making - not a performance of awareness.	

A systems map: from noticing to action

Use this sequence when a classroom issue looks individual but may be shaped by wider conditions.

1
Identity & context

What parts of life and context may matter here? What must we avoid assuming?

2
Power & systems

Which rules, routines, histories, norms, or decision-makers shape the situation?

3
Access & barriers

Who can enter, understand, participate, feel safe, and influence the outcome?

4
Experience & impact

How might the combined conditions create a distinct experience for different people?

5
Action & repair

What change would reduce a barrier, redistribute voice, or improve access? Who should guide it?

Try the lens

A club schedules every meeting at lunch in an upstairs room. Attendance drops. Instead of deciding that students are not committed, use the map: lunch may be needed for prayer, food support, regulation, caregiving calls, or a quiet break; stairs may create an access barrier; meeting language may be difficult for some learners; and only confident speakers may influence decisions. The response is not to identify who has which need. It is to offer varied times, accessible spaces, multiple ways to contribute, clear agendas, and student input on the design.

Scenario cards: look for the interaction

Fictional composites for Grades 5-7 or staff learning. Discuss conditions and design choices - never diagnose the person.

The field trip

A newcomer who uses a mobility device wants to attend a waterfront field trip. The permission form is only in English, the bus plan is unclear, and the class assumes the student will need an adult helper.

Discuss

What barriers come from language, design, attitudes, cost, or decision-making? What would planning with the student and family change?

The history project

An Indigenous, gender-diverse student sees their Nation discussed only in the past and sees gender diversity treated as a separate modern topic. They stop contributing to the project.

Discuss

How do colonial history, representation, gender, and classroom authority interact? Which authentic sources could widen the story?

The assembly

A Muslim student with sensory needs is expected to sit through a loud assembly about belonging. Leaving early is treated as disrespectful, and the only quiet area is beside the stage.

Discuss

How might religion, disability, sound, behaviour expectations, and public visibility interact? What is universal access here?

The homework club

A student who cares for younger siblings is repeatedly late to an after-school homework club. Staff describe the family as uninvolved and remove the student's spot.

Discuss

How might income, family roles, transportation, culture, and school assumptions shape the outcome? What supports avoid blame?

Barrier and belonging map

Choose a space, routine, event, policy, or learning task. Gather input in ways that are voluntary, accessible, and anonymous when needed.

1. What are we examining?

Name the specific space, routine, event, policy, or learning task.

2. What helps people belong and participate now?

Notice relationships, representation, physical access, language access, sensory conditions, timing, cost, safety, and ways to contribute.

3. Where might barriers be produced?

Look at rules, routines, assumptions, design, resources, histories, and who has decision-making power.

4. Who may experience the situation differently?

Consider intersections without guessing or requiring disclosure. What information do we still need, and how can people choose to share it safely?

5. What is one change worth testing?

Aim for a change in access, representation, relationships, policy, environment, or decision-making. Decide how you will know whether it helped.

Text, video, and resource audit

Use before sharing a book, article, video, website, guest speaker, or lesson. A strong resource can still need context or a companion voice.

Check	Questions to ask	Notes / evidence
AUTHORITY	Who created it? What lived, cultural, professional, or community knowledge informs it?	
INTERSECTIONS	Are people shown with multiple, complex identities - or reduced to one label?	
SYSTEMS	Does it explain structures and history, or does it frame inequity mainly as individual prejudice or hardship?	
JOY & AGENCY	Are people shown creating, leading, resisting, caring, imagining, and living ordinary lives - not only experiencing harm?	
ABSENCE	Whose voices, regions, Nations, languages, genders, disabilities, family structures, or class experiences are missing?	
ACCESS	Can learners see, hear, read, understand, navigate, and respond in more than one way? Are captions, transcripts, readable text, and alternatives available?	
CARE	Could the material expose, stereotype, retraumatize, or ask a student to represent a community? What framing, choice, or support is needed?	
ACTION	Does learning end with awareness, or help students imagine solidarity, repair, advocacy, design, or collective action?	

Solutionary action planner

Move from awareness to a manageable change. Let students influence the issue, the evidence, the action, and the reflection.

LISTEN	What are people noticing or experiencing? Whose knowledge should guide us? How can input be voluntary and accessible?
INVESTIGATE	What histories, systems, rules, resources, and decision-makers shape this issue? What evidence is trustworthy?
IMAGINE	What would greater dignity, access, belonging, and shared power look like? Who might still be left out?
ACT	What specific, realistic change can we test? Who needs to be involved? What permissions, care, and resources are required?
REFLECT & REPAIR	What changed? Who benefited? What unintended effects appeared? What feedback, repair, or next step is needed?

Sources and teacher notes

BC Human Rights Commissioner

Intersectionality and systemic discrimination explainers

<https://bchumanrights.ca/glossary/intersectionality/>

Surrey Schools

Journey Forward racial equity commitments and district context

<https://www.surreyschools.ca/racialequity/journey-forward>

FNESC

Authentic First Peoples Resources and First Peoples Principles of Learning

<https://www.fnesc.ca/authenticresources/>

SOGI 1 2 3

BC teaching resources, including First Peoples perspectives on gender

<https://www.sogieducation.org/resources/>

National Inquiry into MMIWG

A rights-based account of colonization, gendered oppression, poverty, housing, health, culture, and 2SLGBTQIA experiences

<https://www.mmiwg-ffada.ca/final-report/>

Rick Hansen Foundation

Disability inclusion, accessibility lessons, and school resource library

<https://www.rickhansen.com/schools-communities/resource-library>

UNICEF Canada

Children's rights and Global Classroom teaching resources

<https://www.unicef.ca/en/node/2476>

Use with care

Intersectionality is not a classroom identity inventory. Do not ask students to rank privilege, reveal protected or private information, or speak for a community. Use public sources, fictional composites, and voluntary input. When learning concerns local Indigenous knowledge, protocols, or histories, seek guidance from the relevant Nation or district Indigenous Education supports rather than treating a general resource as local authority. Links reviewed August 10, 2026; use the Walnut Road hub for updated destinations.